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ARTICLE

A Leopard Doesn't Want to Change His Spots: African American Views on Amalgamation in the Progressive Era

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In 1910 anthropologist Franz Boas proposed ending racial strife by removing recognizable black identities from the American population via racial mixture. Wanting neither to offend a renowned ally nor to risk enflaming white hysteria over the mere specter of "amalgamation," black Americans largely met Boas's proposal with silence. Nevertheless, black views can be discerned through their responses to a similar proposal made the same year by a lesser-known anthropologist, John James Holm, as he solicited black endorsements. The ten black essayists within Holm's book reveal a range of positions on racial mixture. Yet none endorsed Holm's plan. Their responses suggest that Boas's proposal and its disregard for legal wedlock would have garnered even less support. The indirect ways in which the black essayists made their views known on a controversial topic suggests a pathway for historians to restore black thought to a history in which they have been misrepresented and overlooked.

In a 1910 keynote address before the second meeting of the newly founded National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP), Franz Boas, the nation's preeminent anthropologist, rejected the biological salience of racial distinctions. He then told the integrated audience it was "obvious" that "our race problems will become the less intense, the less the difference in type between the different groups of our people." Considering racial discord a consequence of racial difference, Boas argued that making black Americans look more like white Americans via racial mixture would reduce "the acuteness of race feeling."[1] His address initiated a glacial revolution overturning scientific support for biologically separate human races endowed with distinct

[1]Franz Boas, "The Real Race Problem," *The Crisis: A Record of the Darker Races* 1/2 (1910), 22–5, at 25. Boas, a nonobservant Jewish immigrant from Germany, similarly believed that the only means to combat anti-Semitism was assimilation and amalgamation of the Jewish population into the Gentile; "the Negro problem will not disappear in America until the Negro blood has been so much diluted that it will no longer be recognized, just as anti-Semitism will not disappear until the last vestige of the Jew as a Jew has disappeared." Boas, "The Problem of the American Negro," *Yale Review* 10 (1921), 384–95, at 395.

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levels of reason, intelligence, and morality, but his advocacy of racial mixture to solve racial strife never became mainstream.[2] Curiously describing racial mixture as the "one aspect of the solution of the Negro Problem [that] lies entirely in the hands of the Negro," Boas called upon black Americans to support his proposal.[3] Few, however, seemed eager to even acknowledge it.

With blaring headlines across mainstream newspapers, widespread white opposition to Boas's proposal is easily discernible. Black responses proved far more circumspect. Baltimore's *Afro-American*, for example, extensively detailed the two-day NAACP conference but printed nothing on Boas's address.[4] Prominent black attendees like Ida B. Wells-Barnett, Anna Julia Cooper, Mary Church Terrell, and Kelly Miller have no known recorded responses. Boas broke with the white American scientific, legal, and cultural consensus on the existence of biologically distinct human races, but black Americans met Boas's remarks with public silence. How, then, can historians know what they thought of his proposal to eliminate racial strife by eliminating racial differences?

Scholarly attention on racial mixture in the Progressive Era United States has mirrored the disparate levels of black and white responses to Boas's address. Since whites were the ones inscribing bans on interracial marriage into law, penning fearmongering headlines, and carrying out the violence against the supposed violators of the sexual color line, historians' attention has largely been on what whites thought and did. This has resulted in numerous analyses illustrating how interracial marriage bans shaped white conceptions of race and enforced an artificial color line.[5] Such analyses offer extraordinary insight into how whites constructed the idea that interracial unions were unnatural to create a near-unanimous white opposition that undergirded white purity policies, segregation, and white supremacy. Yet, presuming the archives do not offer much on black positions or that black views were immaterial given their dearth of political power, such works offer little on black thought and action.[6] Peter Wallenstein's *Race, Sex, and the Freedom to Marry* (2014), for example, purports to

[2]Mark Anderson, *From Boas to Black Power: Racism, Liberalism, and American Anthropology* (Stanford, 2019), 28–89.

[3]Boas, "The Real Race Problem," 25.

[4]"Second Annual Conference of the National Negro Committee," *Afro-American* [Baltimore], 21 May 1910, 1.

[5]Werner Sollors, *Interracialism*: *Black–White Intermarriage in American History, Literature, and Law* (Oxford, 2000); Charles R. Robinson II, *Dangerous Liaisons*: *Sex and Love in the Segregated South* (Fayetteville, 2002); F. James Davis, *Who Is Black? One Nation's Definition* (University Park, 2002); Elise Lemire, *"Miscegenation": Making Race in America* (Philadelphia, 2002); Karen Woods Weierman, *One Nation, One Blood: Interracial Marriage in American Fiction, Scandal, and Law, 1820–1870* (Amherst, 2005); Sheryll Cashin, *Loving: Interracial Intimacy and the Threat to White Supremacy* (Boston, 2017). Black views on racial mixture since the civil rights movement have received more attention than earlier views. See Paul R. Spickard, "The Illogic of American Racial Categories," in Maria P. P. Root, ed., *Racially Mixed People in America* (Newbury Park: 1992), 12–23, at 19; Renee Romano, *Race Mixing: Black–White Marriage in Postwar America* (Cambridge, 2003), 219–20.

[6]Peggy Pascoe substantially addresses black views and activism, but not until 1913 when she looks at how the NAACP fought newly proposed bans on interracial marriage and Marcus Garvey's support for bans in the 1920s. Peggy Pascoe, *What Comes Naturally: Miscegenation Law and the Making of Race in America* (Oxford, 2009), 163–204.

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tour "all of American history."[7] Never, however, does he focus on black views. Such omissions not only leave unanswered whites' racist charges of black interracial covetousness, but also fail to account for the ways in which black activists combated white supremacy in all of its manifestations and how black and white thought, even when seemingly in alignment, dramatically differed.

Despite being marginalized in much of the history, black discourse over racial mixture proved foundational to the process of black identity formation. Historian Kevin Gaines terms such discourse "part of the larger intellectual struggle of extracting a positive black identity from pejorative racial theories." For Mia Bay, black debate over the issue epitomizes the central tension within black thought—a drive to uphold race pride by stressing the race's uniqueness while defending against racism by emphasizing equality. According to Michelle Mitchell, turn-of-the-century black thought over interracial reproduction reveals a burgeoning concept of race destiny—the "wide-ranging yet singular notion that black people shared a common fate."[8]

Yet still more needs to be done to capture the breadth and complexity of black views, how their positions differed from those of whites, and their recognition of the failures in seemingly antiracist white thought. Black discourse over racial mixture illustrates a divergence not seen in white thought between overwhelming black support for the legal right to interracial marriage alongside widespread black unease with exercising that right. In other words, black Americans fought for the legality of something many personally rejected. Additionally, as William Pickens of the NAACP warned five years after Boas's address, "The lack of adequate knowledge of the Negro's real interest, motives and opinions" was "one of the greatest defects" in white attempts to resolve racism.[9] Had Boas examined nearly any prior black views on racial mixture, he would have seen virtually no support for his ideas. The nation's leading progressive voice on race relations offered a completely unworkable plan to remediate racial strife because he did not understand black thought. Cognizant of white opposition, Boas offered caveats to appease whites but seemed utterly oblivious to or dismissive of even the possibility of black resistance to their own racial obliteration. Such oversights fundamentally hampered his understanding of the very nature of the nation's problem. Eradicating racial distinctions would not dismantle white supremacy and the way he proposed mixture should occur only reinscribed the racial hierarchy he proposed to dismantle.

The perilous nature of the topic for black Americans, particularly in highly visible contexts like Boas's address, however, has made accessing their views difficult. Historian David Levering Lewis aptly described the issue as "deadly delicate."[10] Booker T. Washington insisted that black progress depended upon denying interest in what

[7]Peter Wallenstein, *Race, Sex, and the Freedom to Marry* (Lawrence, 2014), 80.

[8]Kevin Gaines, *Uplifting the Race: Black Leadership, Politics, and Culture in the Twentieth Century* (Chapel Hill, 1996), 121; Mia Bay, *The White Image in the Black Mind: African-American Ideas about White People, 1830–1925* (New York, 2000), 195; Michelle Mitchell, *Righteous Propagation: African Americans and the Politics of Racial Destiny after Reconstruction* (Chapel Hill, 2004), 9, 8.

[9]William Pickens, *The Ultimate Effects of Segregation and Discrimination: The Seldom Thought on the Negro Problem* (1915), African American Imprints Collection, Stuart A. Rose Manuscript Archives and Rare Book Library, 3.

[10]David Levering Lewis, *W. E. B. Du Bois: Biography of a Race, 1868–1919* (Holt, 1993), 425.

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many euphemistically termed "social equality." He even rejected a ten-thousand-dollar donation to his Tuskegee Institute in 1906 on the condition that he debate novelist Thomas Dixon on the matter.[11] Yet this very avoidance of the topic and rote denials of interest itself restricted black thought. As Pickens complained in 1910, "Whenever a Negro begins to speak for the rights of his race he feels it necessary to tell the world that he is not an aspirant after 'social equality' or a defender thereof."[12] Black Americans could not freely engage in public discussions over anything that seemingly fell under the expansive banner of "social equality" without fear of white reprisals. Yet the precarious nature of the topic itself makes seeming archival silences all the more revealing of black priorities. As Alexis Wells-Oghoghomeh found of enslaved women's sexual lives, "what they chose not to say [often] revealed what and whom they valued most."[13]

Black views during the Progressive Era are particularly salient given the period's turmoil. Historian Rayford Logan termed the turn of the century the nadir of American race relations as racial strife and the antiblack violence and rhetoric upholding it had never been worse.[14] Jim Crow decisively limited black rights across the South but was spreading north too, as were attempts to create a biracial order confining all with any known black ancestry to one side of a racial color line. Meanwhile, the black population underwent enormous internal changes. What historian Joel Williamson described as the "great age of passing" (1880–1925) apexed around 1910 as many with ambiguous racial presentations began living as if they were white. Thousands and eventually millions who could not or would not pass sought to lessen their oppression by moving north in what became the Great Migration (1910–70). The generation coming of age were the children and grandchildren of those who had been enslaved and began terming themselves "New Negroes" to denote a break from earlier generations and to mark a new confidence, outlook, and confrontational style.[15] By the 1920s both a cultural outpouring (later termed the Harlem Renaissance) and separately a mass Black Nationalist movement under Jamaican leader Marcus Garvey enticed millions to its ranks and ushered in a celebration of blackness. Simultaneously, the scientific revolution that Boas inaugurated against the biological salience of race spurred self-reflection among black intellectuals over the meaning of race itself. Without a biological basis, many questioned how racial consciousness and solidarity could or should be maintained.[16]

Given the importance of understanding black views at this critical crossroads, scholars must look to underexplored sources where black views did surface. The same year

[11]"From Thomas Dixon, Jr. to Booker T. Washington," 22 Jan. 1906, in Louis Harland and Raymond Smock, eds., *The Booker T. Washington Papers*, vol. 8, *1904–6* (Urbana, 1979), 508; "To Thomas Dixon, Jr. from Booker T. Washington," 25 Jan. 1906, in ibid., 510.

[12]William Pickens, "Intercourse between the Races," in John James Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation* (Naperville, IL), 470–82, at 480.

[13]Alexis Wells-Oghoghomeh, *The Souls of Womenfolk: The Religious Cultures of Enslaved Women in the Lower South* (Chapel Hill, 2021), 112.

[14]While Logan defined the nadir as 1877 to 1901, later historians have argued for later end points. Rayford Logan, *The Betrayal of the Negro: From Rutherford B. Hayes to Woodrow Wilson* (New York, 1997), xxi.

[15]Henry Louis Gates Jr, "The Trope of a New Negro and the Reconstruction of the Image of the Black," *Representations* 24 (1988), 129–55.

[16]Joel Williamson, *New People: Miscegenation and Mulattoes in the United States* (New York, 1980), 103.

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as Boas made his proposal, another white man similarly suggested eradicating racial boundaries via racial mixture. John James Holm, a self-styled anthropologist, solicited black responses to publish inside his book, *Holm's Race Assimilation: Or, the Fading Leopard's Spots; a Complete Scientific Exposition of the Most Tremendous Question That Has Ever Confronted Two Races in the World's History*. The black essayists inside Holm's tome could more freely offer their positions to a far less known white thinker than Boas. Holm asked his respondents their position on interracial marriage being legal, its morality, and whether racial mixture could solve the nation's racial woes.[17] For black Americans, responding to a prominent proposal like Boas's seeking mass racial mixture without regard to legal marriage was an inherently insulting prospect and one laden with peril. Insisting that interracial marriage be legal to a relatively unknown anthropologist represented a far safer and more respectable prospect.

By examining the black responses to Holm's proposal, historians can envisage contemporary black reactions to Boas and thereby start to forge a more complete understanding of black thought in the Progressive Era United States. Even still, assessing black views among Holm's essayists is far from straightforward as many did not directly respond to his inquiries. Akin to politicians asked an unwinnable question, they answered with what they preferred to discuss instead. Their non-answers or alternative answers nevertheless speak volumes about their priorities and favored solutions and suggest how historians might better access black views by looking to what is both said and not said regarding this decidedly delicate issue. Others demonstrated that even seeming agreement with whites could be predicated upon wildly opposite aims. Black opposition to racial mixture was built not on racial chauvinism but rather around "romantic pluralism"—the idea that black Americans should be able to exist alongside whites in equality, in all spheres of life, as they made their own distinct contributions to the world. Or, as eminent black sociologist W. E. B. Du Bois succinctly explained to a predominantly white audience in 1921, "The reasons are ours and not yours."[18] As the white political, cultural, and intellectual establishment consolidated race into a binary structure in the 1910s, many black Americans also sought their own intra-racial unification of sorts, or at the least opposed a purposeful dilution of their race. Their reasons, however, could not have been more distinct from white drives to reinforce their racial dominance.

Examining the black-authored essays within *Holm's Race Assimilation* shows the era to be alive with black discourse over the future of the race, demands for citizenship rights, and drives to foster a positive racial destiny—ideas steeped in concern over reproduction, respectability, and color consciousness. Black Americans welcomed Boas's dismissal of race's significance in terms of human capabilities, yet they mobilized race for dramatically different purposes than both the famed anthropologist and whites seeking to maintain a racial hierarchy. Unlike white hysteria over white racial "purity,"

[17]Holm never explicitly states what he asked respondents, but one of the essayists wrote he was asked "if illicit intercourse was equally hurtful to the morals of both races," while another says he was asked if racial mixture would solve racial strife. Pickens, "Intercourse between the Races," 471; J. W. Smith, "All Human Blood," in ibid., 511–18, at 515.

[18]W. E. B. Du Bois quoted in Paul Spickard, *Mixed Blood: Intermarriage and Ethnic Identity in Twentieth-Century America* (Madison, 1989), 299.

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racial integrity for black Americans meant solidarity for self-protection, race pride, and the race's very survival.[19] That meant seemingly that antiracist calls for the erasure of racial differences, such as Boas and Holm proposed, could prove as threatening to black futurity as white fearmongering over racial mixture to justify white supremacist policies.

Such threats were only compounded by the manners in which Boas and Holm positioned black views. As a Jew and a foreigner, Boas held a liminal position and yet one of purported racial neutrality. His assumption therefore that black Americans should accept becoming white reinforced long-standing tropes that they coveted whiteness. Further, by giving his proposal as the keynote address at an NAACP conference, Boas fueled erroneous allegations that demands for integration represented desires for interracial liaisons. Holm went even further than Boas to misconstrue black positions. Reversing the custom of white abolitionists writing prefaces for slave narratives to authenticate the text's authorship and credibility, Holm literally surrounded his ideas in black "endorsements," with the book's introduction written by a black minister and eleven black-authored essays at its end. Despite claiming that the essayists "scarcely need an introduction," he introduced them in the authenticating style of abolitionist prefaces before presenting each as fully aligning with his proposal.[20]

Far from Holm's framing of the essayists endorsing his plan, they demonstrated black intellectual resistance to white supremacy appearing under the guise of antiracism. Black Progressive Era views on racial mixture revealed a true antiracist path forward in which their race would not have to disappear into whiteness to achieve racial peace but could instead obtain full rights while maintaining black identities. Akin to opposition to "color blindness" today, black Americans at this crucial juncture recognized the flaws in proposals that would deny their experiences, culture, and future, but did nothing to rectify the white supremacy at the core of the nation. The essayists insisted that the right to legal interracial marriage served as a bedrock of equality, even as many hoped that legalizing such marriages would actually decrease the number of interracial relationships.

Progressive Era race making

The white public had long considered racial mixture an abomination. Mere rumor of interracial marriages could incite antebellum antiblack violence.[21] To derail President Lincoln's 1864 reelection campaign, Democrats posing as Republicans even invented a new term, "miscegenation," to that claim the Republican Party promoted inverting the social hierarchy through racial mixture. Widespread white belief in the unnaturalness

[19]Some, of course, disagreed with race pride and advised that white and black interests be aligned. See Frederick Douglass, "The Nation's Problem," 16 April 1889, in John Blassingame, ed., *Frederick Douglass Papers*, vol. 5 (New Haven, 1992), 403–25, at 415; see also Emma Lou Thornbrough, *T. Thomas Fortune: Militant Journalist* (Chicago, 1972).

[20]Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 436.

[21]Linda K. Kerber, "Abolitionists and Amalgamators: The New York City Race Riots of 1834," *New York History* 48/1 (1967), 28–39, at 32–3; Leslie Harris, *In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863* (Chicago, 2003), 197.

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of interracial marriage became, according to Peggy Pascoe, "the foundation of post-Civil War white supremacy."[22] Such beliefs even acquired scientific backing, such as when statistician Frederick Hoffman (1896) catalogued racial mixture's supposed deleterious effects. Mixture, according to such writings, would contaminate white "purity" and lead to national (i.e. white racial) "suicide."[23] The era's most popular fiction, Dixon's avowedly racist *The Leopard's Spots* (1902), presented the era as a dire contest for racial hegemony: "The future American must be an Anglo-Saxon or a Mulatto! We are now deciding which it shall be."[24] Thousands of whites regularly sought to ensure the future's direction through ritualistic, spectacle murder under the guise that only "lynch law" could protect white women from "black brutes." White mobs propagating this "myth of the black rapist" murdered at least four thousand black men, women, and children in the Jim Crow era.[25]

Eugenics, the "science of human breeding," boomed in popularity during the Progressive Era and provided a fresh veneer of scientific rigor for white opposition to racial mixture.[26] Immigration quotas, compulsory sterilization, and marriage restrictions epitomized the confluence of Progressive and eugenic beliefs by purporting to use science to solve social problems. Mainstream American eugenics presented as fact that "race mixing" led to inferior, dysgenic offspring and would "lead to endless friction."[27] As of 1910, twenty-nine states seemed to agree as they barred interracial marriage, and half the remaining states proposed bans soon thereafter. In the white racial imagination, black people were biologically and permanently inferior, racial mixture endangered the white nation, and American law, culture, and extralegal violence reflected this.[28]

Yet, even by the early twentieth century, the white racial milieu had not yet fully built a binary classification system placing all with any known African ancestry on one side of a racial color line. As historian Matthew Guterl describes the era, "'white' and 'black' were not yet stable, easily defined identities." Certainly, the nation was well on its way to a "bi-racialist sensibility," but in 1910 race and color were not yet fully seen as interchangeable.[29] For instance, millions of recent arrivals to the United States, despite hailing from Europe, were not considered "white" by "Old Stock" Americans. Simultaneously, while in practice many were considered black if they had any known

[22]Pascoe, *What Comes Naturally*, 2.

[23]Frederick Hoffman, *Race Traits and Tendencies of the American Negro* (New York, 1896), 178–82; Edward Alsworth Ross, *Social Control: A Survey of the Foundations of Order* (New York, 1901), 161.

[24]Joel Williamson, *Crucible of Race: Black–White Relations in the American South since Emancipation* (New York, 1984), 158; Thomas Dixon, *The Leopard's Spots: A Romance of the White Man's Burden* (New York, 1902), 198.

[25]Angela Davis, *Women, Race and Class* (New York, 1981), 172–201.

[26]See, for example, C. B. Davenport, *Eugenics, the Science of Human Improvement by Better Breeding* (New York, 1910).

[27]William Ernest Castle, *Genetics and Eugenics* (Cambridge, 1921), 267; Paul Lombardo, "Eugenic Laws against Race Mixing" (2000), *Image Archive on the American Eugenics Movement*, at www.eugenicsarchive.org/eugenics/list3.pl.

[28]Paul Farber, *Mixing Races: From Scientific Racism to Modern Evolutionary Ideas* (Baltimore, 2011), 30–43.

[29]Matthew Guterl, *The Color of Race in America, 1900–1940* (Cambridge, 2002), 7, 5.

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black lineage, under the law one could become a different race simply by crossing state lines that varied in their legal definitions. In 1910 Tennessee became the first to codify a "one-drop rule," confining those with any trace of black ancestry to one side of a racial color line. Yet, fearing that "a remote, perhaps obsolete trace of Negro blood" lay within elite families, Virginia only crept nearer to "one drop" that year by moving the color line from those with one quarter to one eighth African ancestry.[30] The Progressive Era project to bifurcate racial categories was decidedly underway but not yet complete when Boas sought to halt its advance.

Racial lines had hardened considerably by the 1920s. Champions of white world supremacy, such as Madison Grant (1916) and Lothrop Stoddard (1920), pushed racial essentialism and biracialist sensibilities to their apex—culminating in the National Origins Act of 1924 favoring migrants from Northern and Western Europe and Virginia's adoption of the one-drop rule in 1924.[31] Subsequently, Walter Plecker—Virginia's registrar of vital statistics, a eugenicist, and leader of the Anglo-Saxon Clubs of America—scoured birth certificates to ferret out those he believed were attempting to pass as white.[32] Where once stood some flexibility or at least ambiguity over racial demarcations, Progressive Era race making codified stark delineations.

Thus Boas's 1910 proposal marked a clear break with the direction of most of the era's racial thought. He tentatively embraced antiracism by rejecting biological significance to racial distinctions and assumptions that racial mixture proved harmful. Nevertheless, he continued to uphold white supremacy by the manner in which he insisted mixture should occur. Boas had not proposed an egalitarian comingling of races into a mixed-race population but the diluting or "bleaching" of the black population to the point of unrecognizability. Rejecting that the white population had to "be infused with a certain amount of Negro blood," Boas instead proposed introducing more white lineage into the black population.[33] Offering a biological solution to what he admitted was a social problem of white racism, Boas insisted that black people need not just assimilate into white society but amalgamate with it to become physically indistinguishable from it.

For Boas, reproduction along the gendered–racialized lines in which mixture had historically occurred with greatest frequency served as the swiftest route to his "raceless" future. Emphasizing that women have a finite reproductive capacity, whereas men could theoretically have an infinite number of children, Boas argued that white

[30]"All Niggers, More or Less!", *News and Courier*, 17 Oct. 1895, 5.

[31]Madison Grant, *The Passing of the Great Race* (New York, 1916); white supremacist Lothrop Stoddard coined the term "bi-racialism" to describe a strict adherence to a color line. Lothrop Stoddard, *Re-forging America* (New York, 1927), 261.

[32]*Virginia Health Bulletin* 16 (March 1924), 1–4; J. Douglas Smith, "The Campaign for Racial Purity and the Erosion of Paternalism in Virginia, 1922–1930: 'Nominally White, Biologically Mixed, and Legally Negro,'" *Journal of Southern History* 68 (2002), 65–106.

[33]Boas, "The Real Race Problem," 25. For Boas, the notion that "the whole mass of the white population might be infused with a certain amount of Negro blood" was a "misunderstanding of the actual conditions of intermixture." The black population would be "infused" with white lineage, not the other way around, according to Boas. He did not address the seemingly inevitable next step when the "lightened" black population became indistinguishable from whites and intermarried.

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male/black female pairings would be the most efficient method for "the relative proportion of Negro blood in the following generations [to] becom[e] less." In other words, Boas called for more white fathers and fewer black ones, as well as reproduction under exploitative conditions as his plan relied upon the long-accepted (by whites) practice of white men having out-of-wedlock children with black women.[34] Despite calling for the violation of the era's biggest racial taboos, in practice Boas's plan fully adhered to white racial norms of exploiting black women and sought not a "raceless" future but a white-presenting one.

With 88 percent of the American population classified as white and 11 percent black in 1910, demographics alone would ensure that the resulting population from extensive mixture would be white-dominated.[35] Martin Delany, often considered the father of black nationalism, had warned of this possibility in 1880: "A general intermarriage of any two distinct races would inevitably result in the destruction, the extinction of the less numerous of the two; that race which preponderates entirely absorbing the other."[36] Yet, for Boas, the fading away of black Americans was more than just a question of numbers, but a white supremacist assumption of which race *should* endure. Although the advancing "one-drop rule" would consider the resulting population from Boas's schema black, the white anthropologist emphasized the retention of white—not black—identities. He did not envision a mixed-race, multicultural population but the disappearance, arguably even the death, of the black population while leaving white identities—and white supremacy—ostensibly unaltered.[37]

Black ethnographers had long insisted that science did not support claims of racial superiority or inferiority and thus might have been presumed to welcome Boas's rejection of race's biological salience.[38] Yet accepting their own racial oblivion proved another matter entirely. When Thomas Dixon claimed five years before Boas's address that "ninety-nine Negroes out of every one hundred" sought mixture and wanted to become white, Howard University Professor Kelly Miller spoke for many of his race when he adamantly denied the accusation. In an open letter, Miller retorted that he

[34]Boas, "The Real Race Problem," 25. A decade later, Boas admitted it would "be in the interest of society to permit rather than to restrain marriages between white men and Negro women," but conceded that "it would be futile to expect that our [white] people would tolerate intermarriages [of black men and white women], although no scientific reason can be given that would prove them to be detrimental to the individual." Franz Boas, *Race and a Democratic Society* (New York, 1945), 80.

[35]The 1910 Census lists black Americans as 10.9 percent of the population and whites as 88.4 percent. *1910 Census*, vol. 1, *Population, General Report and Analysis* (Washington, DC, 1913), 125.

[36]Martin Delany, *Principia of Ethnology: The Origin of the Races and Color with an Archaeological Compendium of Ethiopian and Egyptian Civilizations* (Philadelphia, 1880), 105–6.

[37]A few black voices have suggested racial mixture's relationship to a resolution of the nation's racial woes, but they suggested mutual mixing, such as Douglass's idea of a "composite race" that would embrace all identities rather than the disappearance of one race into the other. Frederick Douglass, "The Future of the Negro People" (1862) in *Frederick Douglass: Selected Speeches and Writings*, ed. Philip Foner (Chicago, 1999), 474–86, at 485. Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 247–8. Holm's solution mirrored federal policy toward Native Americans but would accomplish through marriage what the government aimed to do through "education." Since 1887, federal policy was to "Americanize" Native Americans through boarding schools to eliminate tribal culture, and amounted to cultural genocide. See Ward Churchill, *Kill the Indian, Save the Man: The Genocidal Impact of American Indian Residential Schools* (San Francisco, 2008).

[38]See, for example, Anténor Firmin, *The Equality of the Human Races* (1885) (New York, 2000).

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knew "of no colored man who advocates amalgamation as a feasible policy solution" nor "hope[s] and dream[s] of amalgamation." Miller, in fact, advocated black racial consolidation with "extreme blacks" marrying "those of lighter hue" to form "a more solid and compact ethnic group."[39] Nevertheless, Miller did not denounce racial mixture as he held that even black people who opposed it would not "proclaim that [they are] so diverse from God's other human creatures as to make the blending of the races contrary to the law of nature."[40]

Thus, while black Americans undoubtedly welcomed the denouncement of race's biological salience by the leading white anthropologist, conjoining this with his proffered solution of removing racial differences via racial mixture made Boas's proposition both a nonstarter and a minefield. Like Miller, few openly countenanced the notion of black eradication via the adoption of white identities. Yet, if they spurned Boas's proposed solution, would they also lose the benefits of his rejection of the significance of racial difference? If there were no meaningful scientific distinctions between races, on what grounds could or should they seek to maintain racial integrity? How should the race navigate a new and unfolding scientific landscape while combating the violence and segregation from the old but still vigorous scientific and popular consensus? If they were to accede to Boas's proposal, would that confirm allegations that they sought white paramours and to become white? Such lies excused the lynching of black men and the rape of black women. Even *if* black Americans welcomed Boas's proposition, open agreement threatened their safety. Open dissent risked losing Boas (and his dismissal of race's biological salience) as an ally.

Six months after Boas's address, Du Bois, who had invited Boas to speak at the NAACP meeting, broke his race's silence by featuring Boas's address as the lead article in the second issue of the NAACP's new mouthpiece, *The Crisis*. Presumably not coincidently, the month before publication, Du Bois wrote in another periodical that the "wholesale intermarriage of races during the present generations would be a social calamity" and nothing less than "spiritual death."[41] Although not a new position for Du Bois, these were his most explicit remarks on the subject to date.[42] Never referencing Boas, Du Bois maintained that interracial marriage should be legal in principle but should nevertheless be avoided. In a later publication, Du Bois showed that he opposed not just Boas's proposed solution but his entire conceptualization of the problem. Far from seeing interracial marriage as a means to alleviate racial tension, the "deep seated

[39]Thomas Dixon, "Booker T. Washington and the Negro," in Stanley Feldstein, ed., *The Poisoned Tongue: A Documentary History of American Racism and Prejudice* (New York, 1972), 194–205; Kelly Miller, *As to The Leopard's Spots: An Open Letter to Thomas Dixon* (Washington, DC, 1905), 3–21, esp. 15, 16, 18, 17; Miller, *Race Adjustment* (New York, 1909), 121; Miller, "The Anglo Saxon and the African," *Arena* 28 (1902), 575–84, at 582, 583. While commonly used at the time, the term "amalgamation," like "miscegenation," has a problematic history. Nyong'o terms the former "a political deployment of sexuality through which American subjects were gendered and racialized." Tavia Nyong'o, *The Amalgamation Waltz: Race, Performance, and the Ruses of Memory* (Minneapolis, 2009), 74–5.

[40]Miller, *As to The Leopard's Spots*, 15–16.

[41]W. E. B. Du Bois, "Marrying of Black Folk," *The Independent* 69 (13 Oct. 1910), in *Writings by W. E. B. Du Bois in Periodicals Edited by Others (1910–1934)*, ed. Herbert Aptheker (New York, 1982), 33, at 33.

[42]W. E. B. Du Bois, "The Conservation of Races," in *The American Negro Academy Occasional Papers*, vol. 2 (Washington, DC, 1897), 5–15, at 11.

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racial antagonisms and hatreds" were reason enough for Du Bois to advise avoidance of such unions. He further doubted that even "in the next millennium race lines will wholly disappear."[43] Clearly, the black sociologist's views differed markedly from the white anthropologist's.

Nevertheless, for Du Bois, Boas's denial of race's biological significance apparently outweighed Boas's promotion of a problematic solution. In balance, Boas's address primarily stressed the dearth of evidence supporting the significance of racial distinctions. Only in the last third did Boas present mixture as a solution. Lacking the blaring headlines of mainstream papers and published months after the initial clamor, Du Bois appeared to be directing focus to the position on which he and Boas agreed without imperiling his relationship with an influential ally, who carried far more weight in the academy and who, unlike Du Bois, was considered "objective" on racial matters.[44] Uplifting the antiracist aspects by publishing the address, Du Bois tried skirting its white supremacy by ignoring Boas's concluding proposal and rejecting its central tenets elsewhere. His delicate positioning embodies what Daphne Lamothe describes as black thinkers' critically "adapt[ing] and adopt[ing]" white anthropological insights for their own purposes. They *adopted* what challenged "non-Whites' presumed subhumanity" but *adapted* what reinforced "a Western subject/non-Western object dichotomy."[45]

Holm's Race Assimilation

Such adoption and adaption appeared too in the black-authored essays within *Holm's Race Assimilation*. Promotional material for the book likened its potential influence to that of *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, but the book and the black views within it received little attention at the time and have received little attention by historians since.[46] The massive tome contained over four hundred pages outlining Holm's proposal to solve racial strife via racial mixture. He maintained that his book contained "ample scientific proof that racial admixture is inevitable, that intermarriage prohibition is an outrage to

[43]Vernon Williams described Du Bois as "uncritical of Boas's reservations about black equality." This analysis suggests that black commentators made indirect critiques and withheld larger public discussions on the portions with which they disagreed. Vernon Williams, *Rethinking Race: Franz Boas and His Contemporaries* (Lexington, 1996), 43; W. E. B. Du Bois, "Social Equality and Racial Intermarriage," *World Tomorrow*, 1922, 83.

[44]Since at least 1905 Boas served as a vital scholar for white progressives' black racial-uplift efforts. Lee Baker, *Anthropology and the Racial Politics of Culture* (Durham, NC, 2010), 208.

[45]Daphne Lamothe, *Inventing the New Negro: Narrative, Culture, and Ethnography* (Philadelphia, 2008), 14.

[46]*Cleveland Gazette*, 19 Nov. 1910, 3. Only two historians have cited Holm's work. Michele Mitchell referenced two of the essays. Ingrid Dineen-Wimberly lumps Holm's book with the works of Madison Grant (1916) and Edward Byron Reuter (1918) as all three assessed racial mixing and embraced "pseudoscientific understandings of race." Yet this oversimplifies their differences, particularly the overt racism of Grant and Reuter and the more subtle racism of Holm, and does not assess the black responses. Mitchell, *Righteous Propagation*, 207; Ingrid Dineen-Wimberly, *The Allure of Blackness among Mixed-Race Americans, 1862–1916* (Lincoln, 2019), 43–4.

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human justice," and "that the future greatness of this country depends upon the peaceful assimilation of all its people," via racial mixture.[47] Holm, a Wisconsinite by birth who spent the second half of his life in Florida, had been a student of Orson Squire Fowler, a prominent phrenologist who held that the pseudoscience demonstrated black inferiority.[48] Although Holm has no known record denouncing his mentor's views, he claimed in his book to be a fierce defender of racial equality.

Holm's subtitle, "The Fading Leopard's Spots," not only referenced the day's most popular fiction but sought to overturn its author's central premise. While Dixon condemned racial mixture as a great evil imperiling the (white) nation, Holm stressed that "the variety of races in our country means future greatness and unlimited possibilities; and that when these races are judiciously crossed, scientifically mated, a new man will in time result, with marvelous intellectual and physical powers."[49] Where Dixon saw a threat, Holm envisioned the building blocks of national success. Ostensibly, their views for the nation's future could not have been more antithetical.

Holm considered racial mixture both a solution to racial inequality and ethnologically beneficial. Unlike Boas's dismissal of race biologically, Holm embraced romantic racialism as he considered racial differences real but rejected traditional racial hierarchies.[50] In an argument for "hybrid vigor," Holm deemed the offspring of a white and a black person "a posterity superior to all others." That superiority, for Holm, depended upon the mixing of heterogeneous properties, but also upon the relationship being "in a loving-state." Children born to loving couples, Holm argued, "inherit the excellent qualities of both" parents, while those "imperfectly blended are … inferior to their parents."[51] While Boas seemed unconcerned by legal bars to interracial marriage, Holm abhorred such bans. He considered them "an outrage to human justice, contrary to a fixed law of Nature, [and] demoralizing to both races" as they fueled lynch mobs, promoted out-of-wedlock relations injurious to black women, and hindered the loving attachments he deemed necessary for superior posterity. For Holm, legal marriage would be ethnologically advantageous, moral, and just. Boas, indifferent on the morality, only viewed mixture as a means to erase racial strife with no biological benefits.[52]

Holm's exaltation of hybrid superiority, however, made his arguments parallel long-established white claims that the talents of mixed-race figures were due to their white ancestry. Claiming that "ninety per cent of the so-called 'smart niggers' of superior capability are of mixed breed," Holm thought this stemmed from the mixture itself and not the white lineage. Yet his examples made it a distinction without a difference given that he made no analogous statements regarding talented whites having racially mixed backgrounds. He even speculated that acclaimed figures well known to be of

[47]Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 17–18.

[48]Todd Vogel, *Rewriting White: Race, Class, and Cultural Capital in Nineteenth-Century America* (New Brunswick, 2004), 30.

[49]Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 18.

[50]George Frederickson, *The Black Image in the White Mind* (New York, 1971), 101–2.

[51]Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation,* 391–2.

[52]Ibid., 67, 183–4.

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only African descent, such as poet Phillis Wheatley, had a racially mixed lineage. Holm expressed the antiracist position that "extraordinary ability" was "not confined to any one race," but he reiterated common tropes that discounted examples of black brilliance while leaving all white examples intact.[53] His belief that racial mixture without loving attachments produced inferior posterity also aligned with racist beliefs deeming the mixed population inferior given the long history of enslavers' sexual abuse of black women.

Akin to Boas, Holm deemed racial mixture the swiftest route to racial harmony and likewise stressed that this process need not significantly change the white population as he emphasized the "assimilation by amalgamation of the Afro-American" (not of whites or a merging of cultures or races). Holm declared that "the real Negro," which he defined as a person of entirely African descent, "will disappear in a very few generations" and made no equivalent statement about "real" whites disappearing.[54] Neither Boas nor Holm envisioned a mixed-race nation but a white nation in which the black populace had been diluted away. Ending racial strife, for both anthropologists, meant eliminating the black population. Accepting either anthropologists' position that black people needed to mix with whites to obtain racial peace was akin to accepting long-standing claims that black people were the problem—not white racism.[55] Boas and Holm denied black inferiority and considered whites at fault for prejudice, but their "solutions" called for the black population, not whites or white supremacy, to disappear.

To demonstrate support for his ideas, Holm presented eleven essays by ten black contributors at the end of his tome that he claimed to have "spared neither time nor expense in selecting … for this book," as well as purposefully seeking out a range in ages, "the amount of Negro blood, and other striking physical and mental contrasts." He did not explain his rationale for including only essays by black authors; presumably he had sought essays from whites too but received none, or none he opted to publish. Instead, he cited abolitionists William Lloyd Garrison, Wendell Phillips, and Frederick Douglass as providing "spiritual assistance." Accordingly, he addressed readers not with "I" but with "we" since he believed himself to be cowriting the book with these forerunners.[56]

Holm's essayists

Despite Holm's framing of the essayists as supporting his proposal, none were. While they disagreed with one another in vital ways, all opposed abandoning racial integrity for the promise of racial peace. Removing recognizable black identities *might* alleviate

[53] Although far from the first, Reuter most famously argued that mixed-race people were superior to "pure" Africans but inferior to whites. E. B. Reuter, "The Superiority of the Mulatto," *American Journal of Sociology* 23/1 (1917), 83–106; Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 74–5, 83.

[54] Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 56, 391, 255.

[55] Kendi considers "assimilationist ideas [to be] racist ideas" because they are premised on the assumption that one group needs to change as there is something wrong with them and something right with the group they should assimilate into. Ibram X. Kendi, *Stamped from the Beginning: The Definitive History of Racist Ideas in America* (New York, 2016), 29.

[56] Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 436, 15.

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racial strife but would necessitate abandoning what many considered a unique racial destiny. The essayists proved unwilling to accept such a Faustian bargain and instead offered their preferred solutions for ending racial strife while defending the legal right to interracial marriage as a matter of principle. Holm's essayists, like Du Bois's adaptation of Boas, attempted to foreground what was helpful—such as Holm's stress on the need to legalize interracial marriage—and ignore or rework what was harmful, encouraging widespread mixture that would eliminate the black population. Unwilling to endorse or condemn racial mixture, the essayists instead celebrated racial integrity and demonstrated how removed from their realities Holm's and by extension Boas's proposals were.[57]

Centrally, essayists seemed highly cognizant of the paranoia rationalizing lynching and Jim Crow that made even mention of the topic risky. Thus, like the black silence regarding Boas's address, some avoided the very subject of Holm's work. The book's introduction, penned by M. Edward Church, a minister in the African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church (A.M.E.Z.), for instance, contains no hint of the book's controversial topic as he only uses oblique references to "a cause that concerns the vital interest of both races in America."[58] Two essayists likewise sidestepped direct engagement even as they illustrated their disagreement with Holm. John H. White, an Indiana minister and a doctor of divinity whom Holm described as a "Colored Caucasian" because of his light skin, confined his essay to an origins account of humanity typical of much nineteenth-century black ethnography. He emphasized a single creation event for all humans but stressed a unique role ahead for black people. While White's position can be interpreted as supportive of racial mixture given that he mentions that it occurred throughout history, he also touted the race's potential, ending with a call for equal opportunity to allow his race to "develop into a great, progressive race, and lead again." Reminiscent of Du Bois's 1897 "Conservation of the Races" address maintaining "that Negro blood has yet a message for the world," interracial relationships appeared natural to White but undesirable considering the distinct role he envisioned ahead for the race.[59] He emphasized equality of opportunity as a solution to racial strife, and his silences on interracial marriage itself and Holm's proposal were highly, if subtly, suggestive of disagreement.

Similarly indirect, Alabama teacher Sophia Cox Johnson's essay celebrated black women's strides in respectability since Emancipation. Indignant at varied complexions within a single household, Johnson condemned such visual evidence of "promiscuity." Yet she obliquely presented this as a problem of the past being rectified through racial

[57]So provocative, some might have suspected Holm's work was akin to the 1863 pamphlet coining the term "miscegenation," a cruel fiction meant to discredit black freedom by falsely promoting the notion that the Republican Party actively encouraged racial mixture. [David Goodman Croly and George Wakeman], *Miscegenation: The Theory of the Blending of the Races, Applied to the American White Man and Negro* (New York, 1863).

[58]M. Edward Church, "Introduction," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 19–23, at 21.

[59]Du Bois, "The Conservation of Races," 11; The Reverend John H. White's common name hides him in the historic record despite his educational attainments (doctor of divinity). John H. White, "The Footprints of the Hamitic or Negro Race in History," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 438–46, at 446.

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uplift leading black women to eschew the very types of relationships Boas suggested.[60] Avoidance was the only option in Johnson's mind because interracial marriages, she appeared certain, would not be legalized anytime soon and grandiose theories from Holm or Boas trampled upon her efforts to suppress immorality. Asked by Holm about legalizing interracial marriage, she ignored the question that overlooked her lived reality and instead only praised black women's strides to avoid illicit relationships. Neither she nor White endorsed Holm's position and indeed implied their opposition, yet Holm included their essays as evidence of black support.

William Pickens, who went on to warn in 1915 of the harms of whites' lack of understanding of black views, proved far less circumspect than Johnson and White in his essay. A celebrated and well-known orator who taught classics and sociology before becoming a field secretary for the NAACP, Pickens non-euphemistically thought that the races should get to know one another better and thanked "heaven" that "carnal intercourse … is not the only variety of contact possible between two races." Pickens lamented that whites attached a transgressive stigma to even platonic interactions that forced the race to deny interest in intimate interracial relations. Such denials, Pickens held, had become perfunctory, hampered demands for justice, and stymied day-to-day interactions that he held could actually pacify racial animosity. Racial mixture, particularly as it occurred between the "worst sort," according to Pickens, would not solve "bad intercourse."[61] Legal marriage, he suggested, would be beneficial, but it was only one component of a much larger realm needing reform. Fostering healthy interactions in all areas of life would connect the "better class" of each race and thereby improve relations. Workplaces, churches, and schools, Pickens stressed, needed integrating to allow non-romantic interactions to flourish.[62]

With interracial marriage barred in all states with substantial black populations, most other respondents confined themselves to defending the need to legalize interracial marriage—not to encourage racial mixture but to allow equal rights. James E. Shepard, the president of a training school that is now North Carolina Central University, insisted that "*the State has no right to regulate the social status of the individual*." Widely considered one of North Carolina's most respected black citizens, Shepard's biographer depicts him as a centrist between Washington and Du Bois. For Shepard, marriage was purely a matter for individuals to determine and state involvement was a grave injustice. Yet, like White, Johnson, and Pickens, instead of dwelling on Holm's proposal, Shepard focused primarily on what he considered a surer route to racial peace: ending whites' "color prejudice."[63] Shepard, Holm, and Boas agreed that

[60]Sophia Cox Johnson was little known outside Alabama and her alma mater, Knoxville College. Sophia D. Cox, "Letter from a Worker," *The Aurora* (Knoxville College), 1 Nov. 1897, C. M. McClung Historical Collection, Knox County Public Library. Sophia Cox Johnson, "The Colored Woman on the Plantation, and How She Is Raised by Progress Made," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 504–11, at 508.

[61]Pickens, in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 480.

[62]William Pickens, *Bursting Bonds: The Autobiography of a "New Negro"* (1923) (Bloomington, 1991); Rayford W. Logan and Michael R. Winston, eds., *Dictionary of American Negro Biography* (New York, 1982), 491–2; Pickens, "Intercourse between the Races," 480.

[63]Capitalization and emphasis in this and all subsequent quotes in the original. See Reginald K. Ellis's *Between Washington and Du Bois: The Racial Politics of James Edward Shepard* (Gainesville, 2017); James E.

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the problem lay in white thought but differed on whether that necessitated changing white minds or black bodies.

Magazine editor and poet James E. McGirt, also of North Carolina, likewise endorsed legalization but little more. Freedom, he insisted, required "freedom of marriage and association." The laws inhibiting it therefore "MUST GO." Yet he insisted that he did "not advocate social equality or amalgamation," just as he did not "oppose or advocate gravitation or evolution of the course of the stars. They are fixed by higher laws than those made by human legislation." Racial mixture, to McGirt, simply represented a natural process in need of no elaborate theories in support—such as Boas and Holm provided. Interracial marriage merely needed to be legalized and let alone.[64]

Shepard and McGirt embodied an agnostic position on racial mixture that deemed it neither good nor evil, merely a private choice. Legalization remained a fundamental prerequisite for justice, but individual relationships and these essayists' personal preferences about them were superfluous to the larger principles at stake. The agnostic position would face severe testing in the wake of heavyweight boxing champion Jack Johnson's marriage to a white woman in 1912 (months after a white woman he wed in 1911 took her own life). Irate white legislators introduced bans in half the states without them—seeming confirmation of McGirt's position that "advocacy" of interracial marriage, through a notorious marriage or anthropologists' proposals, incited opposition. A reluctant NAACP, however, lobbied against the proposed bans "not because the Association advocates intermarriage, which it does not, but, primarily, because whenever such laws have been enacted they become a menace to the whole institution of matrimony."[65] *The* (Richmond) *Planet*, a black-authored newspaper, similarly reported that "the majority of the Colored people—and a large majority of them—do not approve" of Johnson's "private actions," but "from the standpoint of personal liberty, a White man has the moral right to marry a Colored woman and vice versa."[66] The *New York Age* likewise held, "We do not need to favor the marriage of blacks and whites as a personal matter, but we do need to stand by the principle that blacks and whites shall be free to marry if they so desire."[67] The NAACP and black commentators were clear that they opposed Johnson's "disreputable" behavior but nevertheless defended his legal right to wed interracially, just as Shepard and McGirt upheld the right as a fundamental component of equal citizenship.

Several essayists grounded their support for legalization in morality. Bishop J. W. Smith, of North Carolina, held that bans should be overturned as he deemed

Shepard, "Color Prejudice in America and Europe—Causes," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 446–54, at 449–50.

[64]James E. McGirt was editor of *McGirt's Magazine* (1903–10), an illustrated monthly on art, literature, and science. James W. Parker, "James Ephraim McGirt: Poet of Hope Deferred," *North Carolina Historical Review* 31 (1954), 321–35; James E. McGirt, "Economic Law Demands Freedom of Marriage," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 483–6, at 485, 486.

[65]National Association for the Advancement of Colored People, *Fourth Annual Report of the Chairman of the Board of Directors for the Year*, Jan. 1914, 9.

[66]*The Planet*, 28 Dec. 1912, as reported in "Booker T. Washington … Does Not Like to Share His Popularity," *Broad Ax*, 4 Jan. 1913, 1.

[67]"Marriage of Whites and Blacks," *New York Age*, 19 Dec. 1912, 4.

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them designed to "besmear filth over the good name of the Black race" as "so-called amalgamation" played out as "fornication and adultery." Smith, known as "the militant writer" for his editorials decrying racial injustices in the A.M.E.Z.'s *Star of Zion* newspaper, believed that there was "no such thing as amalgamation or miscegenation between human beings," as all were "of one blood." Given this, Smith thought "mixed" marriages were "entirely within the range of propriety."[68] Legalization of interracial marriage therefore would prevent lewdness and decrease the number of interracial relationships as he thought many would avoid them if they could be solemnized.

Smith embraced a position typical of many of his race throughout the prior century who treated as catechism the biblical phrase "of one blood" to emphasize a fundamental unity among humanity as all races stemmed from the same creation event (monogenesis) and were thus owed the same rights. The phrase sought to counter white ethnographers' explanations for racial differences stemming from separate creation events (polygenesis).[69] Insisting that all arose from the same origins not only served as a powerful argument against slavery and discrimination but also mandated legalizing interracial marriage.

As Smith underscores, however, adherence to "of one blood" did not equate to embracing interracial marriage as anything more than something in need of legalization. Most directly of all the essayists, Smith responded in the negative to Holm's queries: "I have been asked if I believe that amalgamation or miscegenation between the white and black races will solve the Negro problem. No sir." Thus Smith differed vitally from Holm even as Smith, like Boas, saw no biological significance to race. Racial mixture carried no ethnological benefits for Smith, as no true mixture occurred, so he could only agree with Holm's position on the morality of legalization. Nevertheless, and despite his declaration of naturalness, he professed that he would not "marry outside [his] race." He considered a rationale for the seeming contradiction so commonsensical that it needed no explanation.[70] The unique role White, a fellow minister who had also invoked monogenesis, envisioned for the race as a *race* suggests a possible explanation for Smith's personal opposition.

Another member of the A.M.E.Z. Church, Bishop Alexander Walters, also considered interracial marriage bans deeply immoral. In 1911, Walters, who had been president of the National Afro-American Council, would become vice president of the NAACP. In his essay for Holm's book, Walters held that the exploitation and rape that black women had long suffered were "CRIMES WHICH ARE CALLING ALOUD TO ALMIGHTY GOD FOR VENGEANCE, AND WE ARE COMPELLED TO SUFFER AS A NATION UNTIL SUCH WRONGS ARE RIGHTED." The laws treated black women as "nothing but a 'thing' to be used by [white] men." Ending bans, he insisted, would therefore bring about the equitable treatment of black women—reducing

[68]J. W. Smith, "All Human Blood is Alike—Intermarriage," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 511–18, at 515, 516; George W. Penniman, *Era of Progress and Promise, 1863–1910* (Boston, 1910), 394; "Bishop J. W. Smith Laid to Rest: Large Crowds Pay Final Tribute," *Afro-American*, Oct. 1910, 1.

[69]Bay, *The White Image*, 13.

[70]Smith, "All Human Blood," 515, 516.

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nonconsensual relationships and allowing consensual ones legitimacy. Undoubtedly, Walters, who also wrote passionately about protecting the "sanctity of marriage" in his autobiography, would have been outraged by Boas's acceptance of out-of-wedlock relationships and emphasis on black women's particular role, considering it Boas's admission of black women as mere "things."[71] In the audience for Boas's address, Walters presumably struggled to maintain his composure.

New York teacher and lecturer Anna D. Borden concurred with Walters that interracial marriage bans harmed black women. Yet whereas Walters professed that God's wrath over illicit relationships fell upon the nation, Borden lamented that black women alone bore the stigma. To be "COMPLETELY EMANCIPATED FROM THE THRALLDOM OF THE PAST," Borden held, interracial marriage needed to be legalized. Until that time, black women should treat "any approach of white men as an unpardonable affront." Borden suggested no opposition to interracial marriage itself but decried illicit relationships.[72] She and Holm agreed upon the baneful effects of bans and the unfairness of critiques of black women, but she did not consider racial mixture a solution. Like Walters, she sought legalization to bring about basic freedom, not mass mixture, and also suggested that legalization would lead to less mixture as white men would avoid such relationships if they could be legitimized. For Borden, Boas's proposal and its disregard for legal wedlock and emphasis on black women's role would be especially heinous.

Borden underscores Michelle Mitchell's contention that black discourse on interracial sex was "highly gendered" in an "inequitable fashion," meaning that the burden of avoiding interracial relationships rested primarily on black women.[73] Borden adamantly rejected that onus and wrote a second essay for Holm's book critiquing black, male leaders for their hypocritical stance wherein they condemned the unwed mothers of mixed-raced children yet gladly married their light-skinned offspring. She called for both to be accepted or rejected. Likewise, those who espoused pride in their unmixed complexion, she insisted, should not "'degrade' your offspring with foreign blood." Rather than critiquing mixture, Borden targeted inconsistency and colorism hurting dark-skinned black women in particular and demanded that leaders prioritize repealing bans over condemning black women.[74]

[71] Historian George Miller considers Walters "a consistent centrist," but one who "was a persistent advocate of first-class citizenship." George M. Miller, "'A This Worldly Mission': The Life and Career of Alexander Walters" (Ph.D. dissertation, State University of New York at Stony Brook, 1984), 1–151, esp. 39, 41; Alexander Walters, *My Life and Work* (New York, 1917), 131. Walters, "Miscegenation and Its Baneful Effects," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 486–8, at 488.

[72] Anna D. Borden, not well known until the 1920s, was president of the Fourth Ward Negro Republican Club of Yonkers in 1933 and held a variety of smaller positions in local organizations. "Halt Prejudice, Alderman Urges," *New York Amsterdam News*, 22 Feb. 1933, 10; "Mrs. Charles Borden," *Reporter Dispatch* (White Plains, New York), 13 Dec. 1968; Anna D. Borden, "The Colored Woman as She Is," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 489–96, at 496, 494, 495.

[73] Mitchell, *Righteous Propagation*, 199.

[74] Anna D. Borden, "Some Thoughts for Both Races to Ponder Over," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 497–504, at 498. For a discussion of the types of colorism Borden notes see R. L. Reece, "Genesis of US Colorism and Skin Tone Stratification: Slavery, Freedom, and Mulatto–Black Occupational Inequality in the late 19th Century," *Review of Black Political Economy* 45/1 (2018), 3–21.

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Borden also decried race disloyalty built upon what she considered the conflation of heritage and identity. Some race leaders, particularly men, she bemoaned, brag of possessing white lineage, but Borden held that their identity should be determined by who had best served them—"the dearest person on earth," their mother. Boas and Holm wanted the abandonment of black identities, but Borden sought preservation of race pride and loyalty, irrespective of mixture levels, and thus a more expansive definition for her race. Race pride, for Borden, was a weapon against racism, not an instrument of it, and racial loyalty remained vital irrespective of mixture. Where Boas stressed the "efficiency" of black women having the children of white men to rapidly shed racial differences, Borden celebrated the continuation of black identities via a respect for black motherhood as she held that one could not be "only one-half Negro" if raised by a black mother and abandoned by a white father.[75] Despite such differences, Holm included not just one but two essays from Borden.

Borden and Johnson's positions embodied much of what Margaret Murray Washington, cofounder of the National Association of Colored Women's Clubs (NACWC), termed the "New Negro Woman." Built by Black women's racial-uplift discourse at the turn of the century, such women demanded the same respect as white women received, particularly "authorial control of their bodies." The NACWC's promotion of black women's respectability was deeply tied to purging any illicit associations from past, out-of-wedlock mixture. NACWC national organizer Victoria Earle Matthews, for instance, held that black women were deserving of respect, not stereotypes, as they rebuilt their "ruined castle of honor." Likewise, Mary Church Terrell, the NACWC's first president, maintained that the organization's role lay in the "sacred domain" of building "purer homes." Terrell held that "no sound argument could be produced to prove that there is anything inherently wrong in the intermarriage of the races," but believed that, "under existing conditions," interracial unions "could bring very little happiness."[76] The NACWC took no official position on interracial marriage, yet contended that bans left black women vulnerable to sexual exploitation. Thus, like Johnson and Borden, black women's foremost organization advocated for "respectable" homes and veneration of women instead of accusations against them.[77]

Far from Boas and Holm's aim of spurring mass mixture, decreasing the amount of mixture undergirded Pickens, Shepard, McGirt, Smith, Walters, and Borden's support

[75]Borden, "Some Thoughts," 497.

[76]M. M. Washington, "The New Negro Woman" (1895), in M. H. Patterson, ed., *The American New Woman Revisited: A Reader, 1894–1930* (New Brunswick, 2008), 54–9, at 59; Ayesha Siddiqa, "Reimagining Black Womanhood: Frances E. W. Harper's 'New Negro Woman,'" *Journal of African American Studies* (2022), 37–52, at 39; Treva Blaine Lindsey, "Configuring Modernities: New Negro Womanhood in the Nation's Capital, 1890–1940" (Ph.D. dissertation, Duke University 2010), 2; Victoria E. Matthews, "Some of the Dangers Confronting Southern Girls in the North," in *Hampton Negro Conference* (Hampton, 1898), 62–9; Mary Church Terrell, "The Progress of Colored Women," address to the National American Woman Suffrage Association, Washington, DC, 18 Feb. 1898, Daniel Murray Pamphlet Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, Library of Congress, Washington, DC, 10. Floris Loretta Barnett Cash, *African American Women and Social Action: The Clubwomen and Volunteerism from Jim Crow to the New Deal* (Westport, 2002); M. C. Terrell, *A Colored Woman in a White World* (1940) (New York, 1980), 92–4.

[77]Paula Giddings, *When and Where I Enter: The Impact of Black Women on Race and Sex in America* (New York, 1984), 105.

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for legalization. They offered no ethnological support for mixture and saw legalization as only *part* of the battle to obtain justice. To them, legalizing interracial marriage would not end racial divisions; it would only allow legitimacy and serve the symbolic and practical purposes of protecting black women and promoting equal treatment. Where Boas thought that marriage bans might slightly "retard" the pace of mixture, many of the essayists instead considered bans encouragement for white men to engage in illicit relations with black women, as they could not seek redress if they were abandoned. Unmarried white women could sue ex-lovers for "breach of promise to marry" and even for child support. Black women, who could have no promise of marriage from white men, could not do the same. Indeed, in 1915 Pickens held that "a law to compel fathers to marry the mothers would break up more miscegenation in a week than a law prohibiting marriage will break up in twenty-five years."[78] Legalization, to these essayists, would guard the race from the very loss of integrity that Holm and Boas sought.

Such views aligned with those of leading black contemporaries. Du Bois certainly concurred as he considered interracial marriage bans "an open bribe to amalgamation" and "wicked devices to make the seduction of women easy and without penalty."[79] Fierce antilynching crusader Ida B. Wells-Barnett stressed that bans left "the white man free to seduce all the colored girls he can."[80] Even Booker T. Washington professed to understand why some would fight for legalization. In 1911, he told a researcher that he "never looked upon amalgamation as offering a solution" and held that he knew of "few Negroes who favor it." He nevertheless defended those who sought legalization as not seeking such marriages, "but because they had been led to believe that where race distinctions exist they pave the way for discriminations." Washington proclaimed that while he did "not wholly share this view," he understood their principled attempt to break down legal barriers.[81]

One essayist, however, was somewhat aligned with Holm's and Boas's positions, yet vitally inverted the causal mechanism. Reverend J. W. Wood, a pastor in what Holm described as one "the largest and most cultured churches on the Gulf coast," believed racial mixture to be the ultimate resolution to "bickering," but foresaw a slower and less intentional process than the white anthropologists proposed. Wood thought that social and economic equality would precede widespread mixture, but, once obtained, nothing would be able to halt mixture. At most, he saw mixture and social and economic improvement as coterminous forces and believed that eventually "the Negro race will be a race of 'white Negroes'" through black advancement and white acceptance of that advancement. For Boas and Holm, mixture would produce assimilation; for Wood, equal opportunities would lead to mixture. The physical result might appear the same, with Wood's suggestive phrase that black people would lose their "stainspots," but his

[78]Boas, "The Real Race Problem," 25; William Pickens, "Segregation Is Help to Amalgamation," *Chicago Defender*, 2 July 1927, A1; Pickens, *The Ultimate Effects of Segregation and Discrimination*, n.p.

[79]Du Bois, "Marrying of Black Folk," 33.

[80]Ida B. Wells, *Southern Horrors: Lynch Law in All Its Phases* (New York, 1892).

[81]"From Albert Ernest Jenks to Booker T. Washington," 27 Nov. 1911, in Louis R. Harlan *et al.*, eds., *Booker T. Washington Papers*, vol. 11, *1911–12* (Champaign, 1981), 378; "To Albert Ernest Jenks from Booker T. Washington," 4 Dec. 1911, in ibid., 386–7.

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ordering meant that the races would combine as recognized equals rather than one enveloping the other. In essence, Boas and Holm called for widespread racial passing; Wood foresaw a racial merging.[82]

Wood comes closest to a positive view of interracial marriage. Those with such sentiments tended to see such unions as inhibiting segregation, increasing white allies and empowering black women. Few such views appear among the essayists, although Borden and Walters would welcome legalization's protection for black women. Nevertheless, Borden and Walters envisioned a decrease in interracial relationships with legalization. Wood did not inherently see racial mixture as a positive occurrence, merely a neutral one signaling racial progress in other domains. Charles Chesnutt, the leading black literary figure of the era, although self-described as "seven-eighths white," was one of the era's few black commentators who considered mixture itself to be a positive development.[83] In 1900, he argued that obtaining "homogeneity of type at least in externals" was "a necessary condition of harmonious social progress."[84] Few others held similarly.

While Wood came closest to agreeing with Holm and Boas, another essayist disagreed with the entire purpose of Holm's book and certainly would have considered Boas's proposal harmful. Professor G. E. Davis, of what is now Johnson C. Smith University in North Carolina and a relatively well-known figure, thought white fears over racial mixture irrational but allowed that "there will always be racial peculiarities and distinctions" in the form of race pride that could be "insisted upon," presumably even through legislation. For Davis, the races could coexist without conflict so long as they avoided "topics that arouse useless contention." In other words, Davis believed that whites would eventually allow black Americans to live in peace if everyone left this "bugbear" alone. Practicing this avoidance, most of his essay dwelt on areas of interracial cooperation instead of the questions Holm asked.[85]

Davis comes closest to an avowedly oppositional position. Black contemporaries who opposed mixture tended to do so on the ground of race loyalty and concerns that it fueled racist myths. Smith's profession that he would not "marry outside [his] race" evoked such a stance even as he deemed interracial marriage entirely proper. Johnson and her concern for respectability arguably move her close to opposition, but her views on interracial marriage versus illicit relations could not be differentiated given her indirectness. Pickens, Smith, Walters, and Borden's hopes that mixture would decrease with legalization and White's emphasis on the unique destiny in store for the race suggest that these essayists would at least discourage such relationships, even if their stress on

[82]Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 438. J. W. Wood, "The Afro-American as He Was, Now Is and Will Be. How He Is Bleaching and Will Become Socially Equal," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 519–26, at 521, 525, 526.

[83]Charles Chesnutt to Alice Hanscom, 1 Feb. 1896, in Chesnutt Collection, Fisk University Library.

[84]Charles Chesnutt, "The Future American: A Complete Race-Amalgamation Likely to Occur," *Boston Evening Transcript*, 1 Sept. 1900, 24.

[85]Janette Thomas Greenwood, *Bittersweet Legacy: The Black and White Better Classes in Charlotte, 1850–1910* (Charlotte, 1994), 242; G. E. Davis, "An Optimistic View of the Negro Question," in Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 454–70, at 458, 464, 466.

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legalization kept them in the agnostic camp. William H. Ferris, an educator and minister who later edited Marcus Garvey's *Negro World*, serves as a representative example of a black contemporary opposed to racial mixture. Ferris "honor[ed] the Anglo-Saxon for desiring to keep his race stock pure," but he rejected their methods of bans and violence. He considered interracial marriage an "evil" but a lesser one than out-of-wedlock relations and, accordingly, still advocated legalization.[86] Thus even black opponents of racial mixture rarely supported its ban.

Accordingly, as much as Holm distorted black views when he framed the essayists as supportive of his proposal, he inadvertently provided a revealing range of black views and a suggestive parallel of black thoughts on Boas's proposal. Given that essayists rested their tolerance for racial mixture upon its legality, Boas's proposal would have garnered even less support than Holm's due to Boas's disregard for legal marriages. Boas's priority lay in achieving rapid racial mixture, but the essayists showed a clear preference that *if* racial mixture occur, it should happen within marriages. Far beyond mere Victorian mores, black insistence on legal wedlock centered upon recognition of their fundamental equality. Holm at least recognized the vitality of legal wedlock and thereby garnered partial "adoption." Some were perhaps unwilling to endorse either position for fear of incurring white retribution, but all essayists seemed to genuinely balk at the idea of actively encouraging racial mixture to hasten their own eradication.[87] Instead, they chose to focus on Holm's antiracist portion—legalization—and downplayed other aspects or offered their own preferred solutions. Their seeming silences on Holm's direct queries were in fact expressing their preferred route for ending racism, which did not include changing their racial presentations. Their approaches were akin to Du Bois's emphasis on Boas's rejection of racial hierarchies while he wrote against racial mixture elsewhere. The essayists readily "adopted" legalization, something black activists had long sought, yet they would only "adapt" Holm's and Boas's advocacy of mixture to focus instead on what they considered realistic and desirable alternatives to obtain equality.

Adoption, however, did not mean advocation. *Holm's Race Assimilation; or, The Fading of the Leopard's Spots* received notice in only one black-authored publication. The *Cleveland Gazette*'s glowing review, however, reads like publisher promotional material and is as utterly vague on the book's subject as Church's introduction. Perhaps because the book lacked salacious quotes from black essayists in support of racial mixture, white periodicals ignored it. For black periodicals, as with Boas's address, there was little to be gained from a retort either to Holm's ideas or to his misrepresentation of the essayists, and only danger in drawing attention to it. In contrast, the black

[86]William Henry Ferris, *The African Abroad, or His Evolution in Western Civilization, Tracing His Development under Caucasian Milieu* (New Haven, 1913), 227.

[87]Pro-amalgamation stances like Holm's were rare along both sides of the color line, but there were prominent exceptions. White abolitionist Wendell Phillips maintained that "the secret of almost all progress" would be a racially mixed US. William Allen, one of the first African American professors, believed that the races possessed distinct qualities best in combination. Yet, in contrast to Holm, Allen considered an actual physical blending of the races unnecessary. Multiple races residing together with all permitted to contribute to the nation in equality would produce the same benefits of a nation comprising a blended race. Wendell Phillips, "Speech of Wendell Phillips," *Liberator*, 10 Feb. 1860; "Letter from Wm. G. Allen," *Frederick Douglass's Paper*, 10 June 1852, 20 May 1852, 7 July 1852.

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press dwelt at length on the accusations in the novel to which Holm's title alludes.[88] Denouncing the clear racism of Dixon's *The Leopard's Spots* proved far savvier than tackling Holm's or Boas's pretense of antiracism.

Misrepresenting black thought

Despite Holm seeking out black responses, he seemed oblivious to their actual views. No essayist recommended that racial mixture be pursued or that it held ethnological benefits. Instead, they disavowed Holm's plan, confined themselves to legal principles, or avoided the topic to advance their own solutions. While most essayists endorsed the right to interracial marriage in principle, none upheld it as a solution. Racial mixture, to the essayists, at most would result *from* racial peace, not create it. Just as integration demands were about equal access, not a desire to mingle with whites, the essayists did not seek racial mixture; they wanted an equitable society, not an erasure of black identities. Holm, however, presented himself and the black essayists as so aligned that they "complete [each other's] arguments."[89] The range of at best semi-agreement, non-endorsements, and rejections that he published indicates that he received far less support than he presented himself as having, or did not understand the vital differences between his proposal and the essayists' positions. Either way, his framing of the essays commodified black thought for white consumption by stripping away the essayists' critiques that white society, not black bodies, needed to change to obtain racial peace.

Both Boas and Holm discounted black opposition and presumed that black Americans would welcome the "opportunity" to become white. Both failed to understand the role of black race pride or that it fundamentally differed from white race pride. Confident that the "scientific" principles he espoused would be deemed unassailable, Holm argued that a more "logical" recognition of racial categories than the one-drop rule would soon arise. His ill-placed certainty aside, until his or Boas's ideas took hold, those who wanted to obtain the rights of citizenship would not be able to admit to any black ancestry and thus would have to renounce their racial identity and community for the hope of obtaining basic rights. The choice looked little different from racial passing and all the loss that entailed—a loss both Boas and Holm were openly dismissive of.[90] Indeed, Holm considered "stupid race pride" among black Americans "a fad," the "warped" effects of white propaganda, and a "disease" contracted from southern whites. He even deemed black pride partially responsible for discrimination: "Any Negro who boasts of the purity of his blood … is his own greatest enemy, not because of the fact that he is pure, but because the anti-Negro sentiment is thereby incensed." Boas likewise called for the rejection of black solidarity: "The less Negro society represents a party with its own aims and its own interest distinct from those of the members of the

[88] *Cleveland Gazette*, 19 Nov. 1910, 3. For examples of black rebuttals to Dixon's novel see R. R. Downs, "The Leopard's Spots," *Christian Recorder*, 24 July 1902, 1; Downs, "'The Curse of Caste' vs 'The Leopard Spots'," *Afro-American*, 15 Aug. 1903, 4.

[89] Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 437.

[90] Ibid., 125; Allyson Hobbs, *A Chosen Exile: A History of Racial Passing in American Life* (Cambridge, 2014).

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white race … the more satisfactory will be the relation between the races."[91] By failing to understand the role of black race pride, Boas and Holm could neither anticipate nor understand black opposition.

Both also seemed oblivious that racial mixture would not provide relief from Jim Crow. Given laws in 1910, save Tennessee, the mixtures they proposed would have *eventually* placed the resulting progeny on the white side of the law. They either could not anticipate the move to render as nonwhite all with *any* black lineage, or sought with their proposals to stem the tide of such laws. In 1921 Boas speculated that "in a race of octoroons, living among whites, the color question would probably disappear."[92] Yet the US Supreme Court had already made abundantly clear in *Plessy* v. *Ferguson* (1896) that segregation applied even to those with one-eighth African ancestry. Being an "octoroon" did not prevent Homer Plessy, the plaintiff in the infamous "separate-but-equal" case, from being confined to the "colored car."[93]

Had Boas sought black testimonials for his proposal, he likely would have been met with a sidestepping of the subject. The evasive strategies that Holm's essayists employed, even with the less respected white thinker, illuminate the general silence surrounding Boas's address and underscore the difficulty, but necessity, of seeking out black views. Had Holm or Boas critically examined nearly any prior black writings on the subject or merely taken black people at their word when they continually denied allegations that they coveted white paramours, Boas and Holm should not have been surprised by the lack of support for anything more than legalization. The consistent refrain from black commentators throughout the previous century and into the twentieth was an "emphasis on two not always compatible themes: human sameness and racial distinctions."[94] Black Americans fiercely maintained their equality with whites (thereby necessitating interracial marriage's legality), but few were willing to consent to the erasure of what many considered their unique racial destiny or abandon the security and support of racial solidarity.

Through either obliviousness or disregard, Holm distorted black positions just as much as Thomas Dixon when he had earlier claimed that "ninety-nine Negroes out of every one hundred" sought to become white. Nearly all of the essayists defended the legal right to interracial marriage, but Holm conflated that with black embrace of his plan for mass racial mixture. As the essayists made clear, they agreed with Kelly Miller that supporting the right to interracial marriage was the "expression of a belief, not the utterance of a preference."[95] Black support for interracial marriage stood on principle, meaning that even those opposed to it would not condemn it as unnatural. Calling for mass racial mixture—in or outside legal wedlock and in a manner intentionally aiming for the disappearance of the black population—was never going to win black support. As David Walker put it nearly a century earlier, those who would "slave his own colour"

[91] Holm, *Holm's Race Assimilation*, 258, 327, 259, 327; Boas, "The Real Race Problem," 25.

[92] Franz Boas, "Problem of the American Negro," *Yale Review* 10 (1921), 384–95, at 395.

[93] *Plessy* v. *Ferguson* 163 U.S. 537 (1896).

[94] Bay, *The White Image*, 54.

[95] Miller, *As to the Leopard's Spots*, 15.

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to marry someone "just because she is *white* ought to be treated by her as he surely will be, viz: as a NIGER[*sic*]!!!!!."[96]

Conclusion

Despite very different schemas, both Dixon and Holm used black insistence that interracial marriage be legal to allege black support for racial mixture. Boas at least made no assumption of black support even as he put the onus on them to accept the unequal ways in which he proposed mixture should occur. Dixon, Holm, and Boas could not account for the ways in which black thought differed from white thought, envision a nation in which racial difference and racial equality coexisted, or seek a "raceless" future that was not in fact a white future. Dixon and the white anthropologists ostensibly sought very different futures, but the results of each approach would be the same: black subordination to whites, through racial caste or racial absorption. Black commentators recognized the overlap and rejected all iterations. They remained as unconvinced by the "racist anti-racism" of Boas and Holm as they were by Dixon's overt racism.[97]

Progressive Era black Americans did not see racial mixture as a solution but did not deem it unnatural either. To deny their right to marry interracially would be a denial of their common humanity. To concede the naturalness of interracial marriage would be a forfeiture of equality. Black and white opposition to racial mixture, in other words, substantively differed as most black opponents still deemed it natural, just undesirable. Black support also differed from white support as few black "proponents" wanted anything more than its legality. They needed to maintain their race's humanity while also upholding differences in character and potential destiny to promote race pride. They had to transcend racial categories to demand citizenship rights but needed racial solidarity to protect themselves from racialized attacks and sought to maintain an identity to vindicate their race's capacity.[98] Boas and Holm failed to understand black solidarity and pride as functionally antithetical to how white solidarity and pride operated.

As Miller put it in a retort to Dixon's allegations of black interracial covetousness five years ahead of Boas's address and Holm's book, "Civilization is not an attribute of the color of skin, or curl of hair." Accordingly, he saw no need for physical changes to assuage white racism. Black hearts "already beat at a normal human pace"; thus, Miller asked, why "would you desire to change?"[99] Whether from racial provocateurs such as Dixon, who aimed to strengthen racial barriers, or Boas and Holm, who

[96]David Walker, *Appeal to the Colored Citizens of the World* (1829) (University Park, 2002), 11.

[97]Both Holm and Boas embody what Lee Baker termed "racist anti-racism" as they advocated antiracist research and ideas but promoted racist aims, such as assimilation. Lee D. Baker, "The Racist Anti-racism of American Anthropology," *Transforming Anthropology* 29/2 (2020), 127–42. See also Kamala Visweswaran, "Race and the Culture of Anthropology," *American Anthropologist* 1/1 (1998), 70–83.

[98]Bay, *The White Image*, 36. Marcus Garvey is a prominent exception as he openly favored legal bans to interracial marriage. Barbara Bair, "Remapping the Black/White Body: Sexuality, Nationalism, and Biracial Antimiscegenation Activism in 1920s Virginia," in Martha Hodes, ed., *Sex, Love, Race: Crossing Boundaries in North American History* (New York, 1999), 399–419, at 399.

[99]Miller, *As to the Leopard's Spots*, 15, 13.

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hoped to destroy racial boundaries, all assumed that black Americans would consent to becoming white and distorted black views to meet their agendas. They either sought black subordination through genocide, racial terror, and racial hierarchy, or wanted a genocide of another type—the complete disappearance of black identities through their obliteration into whiteness. Recognizing the similarities in whites' mainstream calls for segregation and fringe proposals for complete amalgamation, Miller, Du Bois, the essayists, and even those who did not deign to respond to Boas's proposal sought equality without having to fundamentally change to appease white racism; they wanted interracial marriage legalized not to enter a "raceless" future but to ensure basic equality.

Despite being misrepresented for white consumption, Progressive Era black commentators upheld what was useful in white thought and subverted what was not. Without a specific focus on black views, even accounts incorporating black support for legalizing interracial marriage can overlook how that support differed from white support. Legalization was not only fundamental for equality and justice, but would, many black commentators hoped, reduce the number of interracial relationships. This position put many in the seemingly paradoxical position of fighting for interracial marriage's legalization to *support* racial integrity.

Historians must also consider the tremendous constraints under which black commentators expressed their positions, both the violent repercussions in an age of lynching and the political considerations of opposing apparent white allies. Black commentators sometimes needed to express themselves in indirect ways that historians must carefully glean from the occasionally meager existent record of black thought. Their positions are nonetheless present even in the silences. The delicacy with which many handled the risqué topic further underscores the need to appreciate the skill with which they made their views known. The black essayists' focus on topics other than what was asked of them reveals both the guarded nature of their responses and their savvy methods to "adapt" an undesirable proposition by making their own priorities known instead. The masked responses accordingly also suggest that black-authored positions produced for a white-authored publication surely differ from private, intra-racial discourse in which their views could be more safely given.

Progressive Era black commentary on racial mixture illustrates a wide spectrum of thought during a perilous time but reveals a consistent drive for racial equality *and* racial preservation too often mischaracterized to fit the agendas of white men as diverse as Thomas Dixon, John James Holm, and Franz Boas. Black views on racial mixture were far from homogeneous or simple, but their commitment to justice was clear, even against the mischaracterization endemic in disparate white views. Progressive Era black Americans sought to assert their race's humanity while also preserving differences in character amid changing conceptions of race and increasing constraints placed on it.

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